

Devices: Any devices you add that can interact with Modern UI apps will show up here.

Ease of Access: Here you can configure assistive technologies such as high contrast mode, and narrator.

Sync your settings: If you use a Microsoft account to log in rather than a local account, Windows 8 will be able to sync a number of your settings with Microsoft's cloud. These include personalisations, stored passwords, language settings, app settings, browser settings etc.

HomeGroup: Microsoft added HomeGroups in Windows 7 as a simpler way of setting up home networks. This feature is still available in Windows 8 and here is where you can configure it. The old way of configuring these settings is still available, so unless you have a pure touch screen, there isn't much point using it here.

Windows Update: This is the simplest page of all. If there is an update, it will show that you can do something about it. Otherwise you can check for updates.

New Ways to Log In

We mentioned earlier that it was possible to set up a user account using your Microsoft account. While this does make keeping things in sync a lot simpler – as you will learn later on – chances are you have and want to keep a complex password for your online account. Such passwords are OK on a desktop, but typing them out repeatedly on a tablet without a physical keyboard can be a pain. Even if you are only using a local account with a simpler password, Windows 8 offers some alternatives that might serve you better.

The first is a PIN-based login, which is essentially a 4-digit numeric code for your computer. The great thing about this is that all you need to do is enter the pin and it will automatically log in the second you enter the final digit of your pin, no need to even press enter!

If you want a little more security though and you have a touch screen, Windows 8 has a better solution, Picture passwords. What picture passwords let you do is to use a picture of your choice in combination with a series of gestures to log in.

The password is then a series of three gestures, performed in the right order. A gesture could be a simple tap, a straight line, or a circle. You pick a picture that provides the points of reference since you can perform gestures on the items on the screen. This can be used with a mouse as well, but is not as comfortable as it would be with a touch screen.